

Some scientists think there may be a planet around Betelgeuse

Betelgeuse lies around 640 light years away from Earth in the constellation of Orion

LIFE OF A HEAVYWEIGHT STAR

The heaviest stars have the hottest cores, and burn the fuel in their nucleus so quickly they die after only 10 million years. The reactions take place in a series of stages.



1 Soon after forming, a star begins a long period in which it hardly changes, as hydrogen is converted to helium in its core.



2 When the hydrogen starts to run out, changes in the core create extra energy and cause the star's outer layers to swell and form a red supergiant.



3 The supergiant explodes as a supernova and blows off its outer layers, leaving behind only its core, which begins to shrink. It will then become either a neutron star or a black hole.